

How to Cook Canned Black Beans

An easy way to season canned black beans into a flavorful side dish in under 20 minutes.

SERVES
4

PREP
10 min

COOK
8 min

DIFFICULTY
Easy

If you've got a can of black beans and a few pantry staples like onion, tomato, and garlic, you've got everything you need for a side dish that tastes nothing like beans straight from the can. The whole process takes under 20 minutes. Serve alongside rice, tacos, enchiladas, or fajitas — or eat them on their own with tortilla chips and cheese.

Aromatics & Seasoning

Sautéed first to build flavor

Olive oil	1 tbsp
Onion, minced	½ large
Plum tomato, minced	1
Jalapeño, minced (optional)	1
Garlic, minced	1 tsp
Ground cumin	½ tsp
Dried oregano	¼ tsp
Smoked paprika	¼ tsp

Garlic is about 2 minced cloves. Leave jalapeño seeds and veins in for more heat, or remove for mild.

Beans & Finishing

Added after the aromatics soften

Black beans, 15-oz can	1
Lime juice	1 tbsp
Salt	to taste
Cilantro, chopped (optional)	for serving

Directions

BUILD THE FLAVOR BASE

- 1 Heat oil in a medium saucepan over medium-high heat.
- 2 Add onion, tomato, jalapeño (if using), garlic, cumin, oregano, and smoked paprika. Stir and sauté for 5 minutes, until onions have softened and turned translucent.

ADD BEANS & FINISH

- 1 Add the can of black beans, including the liquid (do not drain). Stir and bring to a simmer. For a soupier consistency, add water or broth to taste.
- 2 Remove from heat and stir in lime juice and salt to taste.
- 3 Garnish with chopped cilantro and serve.

Tips & Variations

- Use the whole can including the liquid — it carries a lot of flavor and helps build the sauce.
- Leftovers keep about 4 days refrigerated; great stirred into rice bowls or spooned over tacos.
- No jalapeño on hand? A pinch of cayenne or a dash of hot sauce works as a swap.

Nutrition information is not provided and will vary based on portion size and specific ingredients used. Consult a registered dietitian for guidance on your dietary needs.